

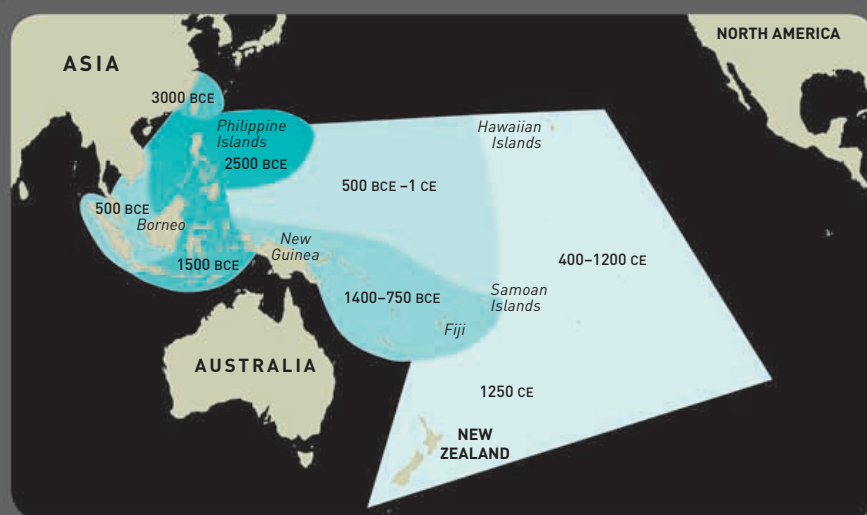
COLONIZING THE PLANET

THE SPREAD OF MODERN HUMANS ACROSS THE WORLD

Skeletal and DNA evidence suggests that our species, *Homo sapiens*, evolved in Africa and then spread across the globe. The first traces of modern humans beyond Africa come from fossils in Israel and possibly from stone tools found in Arabia. They date to before 100,000 years ago.

Homo sapiens' colonization of the globe involved many stops, starts, and sometimes retreats, as well as waves of different groups of people in some areas. *Homo sapiens* may have moved into Eurasia via the Mediterranean coast of western Asia, spreading into Western Europe by 35,000 years ago (YA). Archaeological evidence suggests that people may also have taken a "southern route" across Arabia into southern Asia. There may also have been movement eastward, perhaps much earlier, as stone tools have been found in India from 77,000 YA and Malaysia from 70,000 YA. Some possible *Homo sapiens* finds from southern China are dated to 68,000 YA (Liujiang), and even 100,000 YA (Zhirendong). However, these finds remain controversial, and most scholars favor later dates here. In Australia, widespread colonization probably did not occur until 45,000 YA, though some sites have been dated to as early as 60,000 YA.

Farther north, *Homo sapiens* first spread across northern Eurasia around 35,000 YA. However, they may have retreated during the last Ice Age, and not recolonized the region until after 14,000–13,000 YA. Genetically, the North American colonists are likely to have originated in East Asia. They probably traveled across the plain of "Beringia"—now beneath the Bering Straits between Siberia and Alaska, but exposed by low sea levels at the height of the last Ice Age. Distinctive "Clovis" spear points (flaked on both sides) are found across North America around 12,000 YA, so modern humans were widespread at that point, but earlier sites are also known, including South American sites such as Monte Verde (15,500–15,000 YA).



LATE ARRIVALS

The islands of Oceania were some of the last parts of the globe to be colonized, via the Philippines, by Austronesian-speaking early farmers from Taiwan. The more remote northern and eastern islands of Micronesia and Polynesia remained uninhabited until after 700 CE, and New Zealand was populated as late as 1250 CE.

Tracking language

The spread of languages can often be tracked to reflect the movement of people. This map shows the spread of Austronesian speakers across Oceania. Earlier settlers were already present in some western areas.

